

External Optical Drives

Sony DRX-830UL-T

Specifications

Write: DVD-R / +R: 18x; DVD+RW / +R DL / -R DL: 8x; DVD-RW: 6x; DVD-RAM: 12x; CD-R: 48x; CD-RW: 32x
Read: DVD-ROM: 16x; CD-ROM: 48x
USB 2.0; i.LINK FireWire; dimensions: 5.08 x 16.51 x 24.89 cm; weight: 1.59 kg

Our Verdict

This drive performed toe-to-toe with its *internal* counterpart, when writing a DVD-R or a DVD+R or even a CD-R. It supports hi-speed USB 2.0 as well as FireWire.

Sony provides a manual and a quick setup guide on CD. It comes with Nero and Roxio Toast 6 Lite DVD/CD.

A stand is provided so the drive can be placed in an upright position, thus saving valuable desktop space. Sony also provides USB and i.LINK FireWire cables, so no additional expenses for you.

With the lowest price in its category as well as the best performance and features, we have no reservations in awarding the Sony DRX-830UL-T the Zero1 Award for this category!

Runner-Up: NA



SPEAKERS

2.1 Speaker Sets

Altec Lansing MX5021

Specifications

90 W RMS total power (50 W subwoofer, 20 x 2 W satellites); subwoofer 6.5-inch driver; satellites: 2 x 3-inch mid-range drivers and 1 x 1-inch horn-loaded tweeter; wired control pod with volume, treble, and bass settings; fully-functional IR remote

Our Verdict

The MX5021 is one of the only speaker sets we've seen that faithfully reproduces sound as neutrally as possible throughout the audible spectrum. The bass that its 50-watt subwoofer belts out is deep and resonating, yet

very defined. The mid-range is excellent, and the horn-mounted tweeter gives sharp, piercing highs.

The wired control pod and IR remote add convenience to an already strong package. Some might think these speakers a tad pricey, especially when compared to many of the el cheapo 5.1s out there... but we urge you to trust us and pick one of these sets up if you like to pamper your ears! Acoustic indulgence can't get much better!

Runner-Up: Altec Lansing FX6021



5.1 Speakers Sets

Philips MMS 5.500 i/C

Specifications

Total power 75 W RMS (subwoofer 25 W RMS, satellites: 4 x 10 W + centre speaker 10W); remote control

Our Verdict

A 5.1 that can excel at a surround sound experience and please the listener with stereo performance is rare indeed. So many speakers these days promise much to one particular audience group and fail to deliver to others. This set will easily satisfy the music lover with sterling performance when playing audio CDs

and MP3s. What was most noticeable was the quality of the highs: typically, 5.1 sets are more geared towards movies (and therefore bass with some mid-range).

Build quality has always been an issue with most 5.1s. Since they don't always sit on your desktop, sturdiness of build is something we always look at. Another top spot for these speakers—they're built like little tanks! The subwoofer isn't too large to spoil aesthetic appeal, yet belts out enough bass to assure you of its presence... emphatically!

Runner-Up: Philips HTR 5000

